

Pictures and the Decline of Literacy

Key words and phrases from the article • Level B

The words and phrases below appear in the article *Pictures and the Decline of Literacy*. Study the full table carefully, then complete the gap-fill exercise in Part 2. Most sentences require more than one answer.

PART 1 — VOCABULARY TABLE

WORD / PHRASE	DEFINITION	EXAMPLE SENTENCE
literacy	the ability to read and write; the level of reading skill in a population	<i>Declining literacy rates in British schools have prompted urgent educational reforms.</i>
illiteracy	the inability to read or write; a lack of basic reading skills	<i>The fruitless search for the cause of illiteracy has missed the most obvious explanation.</i>
empirical evidence	information gathered through observation and experiment rather than theory or assumption	<i>There is virtually no empirical evidence to support the use of pictures in teaching reading.</i>
illustrations	pictures or images in a book, used to support or decorate the text	<i>Illustrations in reading primers have become increasingly detailed and obtrusive over recent decades.</i>
obtrusive	noticeable in an unwanted way; standing out too much and causing a distraction	<i>The artwork was obtrusive — it dominated every page, leaving almost no room for language.</i>
impoverished	made poorer or weaker; lacking in richness or variety	<i>As pictures have grown larger, the language in children's books has become increasingly impoverished.</i>
redundant	no longer needed because something else performs the same function	<i>When every page has a detailed picture, the written words become redundant — children have no need to read.</i>
comprehension	the ability to understand what is read or heard	<i>Reading fluently is not enough — true comprehension means understanding the meaning of the words.</i>
fluently	smoothly and with ease; without hesitation or difficulty	<i>A child may be able to read aloud fluently while understanding almost nothing of what they are saying.</i>
innate	existing naturally from birth; not learned or acquired through experience	<i>The author argues that children need to have their innate powers of imagination trained through reading.</i>
impedes	slows down or prevents the progress of something	<i>Anything which impedes the development of literacy is a serious matter for society as a whole.</i>

WORD / PHRASE	DEFINITION	EXAMPLE SENTENCE
primers	basic books used to teach young children to read, often the first books a child receives	<i>In reading primers, illustrations have grown increasingly detailed while language has almost disappeared.</i>
detrimental	causing harm or damage; having a negative effect	<i>Academic journals cite experiments demonstrating how detrimental pictures are for beginner readers.</i>
psycholinguistics	the scientific study of how people understand, produce, and learn language	<i>Research in psycholinguistics shows that pictures actively interfere with children's language acquisition.</i>
stimuli	things in the environment that cause a reaction or response (singular: stimulus)	<i>Children given no illustrated stimuli at all learnt significantly more words than those given pictures.</i>
formative	relating to the period or experiences that have a major influence on development	<i>It is hard to wean children off pictures when they have played a part in all their formative reading experiences.</i>
wean off	to gradually cause someone to stop depending on something they are used to	<i>It becomes very difficult to wean older children off pictures once they have relied on them from the beginning.</i>
barking at text	reading words aloud correctly without understanding their meaning	<i>A child who reads every word correctly but understands nothing is said to be 'barking at text'.</i>
socio-economic	relating to both social and economic factors considered together	<i>The search for the cause of declining literacy has so far focused mainly on socio-economic factors.</i>
prompted	caused something to happen or encouraged someone to take action	<i>The alarming literacy statistics helped to prompt massive educational changes across Britain.</i>
offset	to balance or reduce the negative effect of something with something positive	<i>The adverse effects of poor language at home can be offset by experiencing rich language at school.</i>
far-reaching	having a wide range of effects or consequences that extend well beyond the immediate situation	<i>The development of literacy has far-reaching effects on a child's general intellectual development.</i>

PART 2 — GAP-FILL EXERCISE

Complete the sentences using the correct word or phrase from the word bank below. You may need to change the form of the word. Most sentences require more than one answer.

WORD BANK

literacy	illiteracy	empirical evidence	illustrations
obtrusive	impoverished	redundant	comprehension
fluently	innate	impedes	primers
detrimental	psycholinguistics	stimuli	formative
wean off	barking at text	socio-economic	prompted
offset	far-reaching		

1	The fact that 30 per cent of British 16-year-olds have a reading age of 14 or less has _____ massive educational reform, given that poor _____ has _____ consequences for intellectual development.
2	The search so far has focused on _____ factors or teaching techniques, but the real cause may be far more obvious and has been hiding in plain sight.
3	For the past two decades, _____ in reading _____ have become increasingly detailed and _____, while language has become _____ — sometimes to the point of extinction.
4	There is virtually no _____ to support the use of _____ in teaching reading — on the contrary, a great deal of evidence shows they are actively _____.
5	Even a child who can read aloud _____ may struggle with _____; this is what educators call '_____ ' — sounding out words without understanding their meaning.
6	When a book is full of detailed pictures, the written language becomes _____ — children have no need to engage with the text because the image does all the work for them.
7	Children need to practise using their _____ powers of imagination; if pictures do the imagining for them, this vital creative skill can never be properly trained.
8	Anything which _____ the development of _____ is a serious matter — including the very tools that educators have assumed, without _____ evidence, to be helpful.
9	It is very hard to _____ children _____ illustrated books once pictures have played a central role throughout their _____ reading experiences.
10	The adverse effects of poor language at home — from television, video games, or limited reading — can be _____ by experiencing rich language at school.
11	Academic journals across _____, psychology, and language learning all cite experiments showing how _____ pictures are as _____ for beginner readers.
12	Children who were given no illustrated _____ at all learnt significantly more words than those who learnt from books containing pictures — a finding that challenges decades of educational practice.

13	Dale Willows found that the closer the pictures were to the words, the slower and more inaccurate the child's reading became — a clear example of how _____ images can be.
14	The response of educators to declining _____ has been to add more pictures and simplify the language further — a solution which, the evidence suggests, only makes the underlying problem worse.
15	If we use pictures to save children the trouble of developing their creative skills, the author argues, then we are doing them a serious disservice — one with potentially _____ consequences for their intellectual future.

Write your answers here:

1. _____	2. _____	3. _____
4. _____	5. _____	6. _____
7. _____	8. _____	9. _____
10. _____	11. _____	12. _____
13. _____	14. _____	15. _____